silent about Afzal's relationship with the STF for the same reason that it was so vocal in loud mouthing S.A.R. Geelani's presumed culpability in the same case. The mainstream media, to a very large extent, is not an organ that takes orders from the intelligence apparatus. It is, in fact, a *part* of the intelligence apparatus. The 13 December case will go down in the history of modern India as an instance that revealed the extent of embedding of the intelligence apparatus of the Indian State within the so-called 'free' media in India.

In this delicate game of silence and overstatement, the courts have based their indictment of Afzal partly on the statements made by him and partly on confessions extracted under brutal physical and mental torture in police custody, and the majority of the reporting in the media has conveniently overlooked the fact that the names that have been named by Afzal in these very statements point in the direction of the Indian government's security, intelligence and counter- insurgency apparatus in Jammu and Kashmir. The 'needle of suspicion', to use another favourite Supreme Court phrase, is pointing all over the place, but no one seems to be looking. There is a pattern here that we need to recognize—when things are obvious, look away, and when truths need to be manufactured, use every tool in the book to manufacture them.

We need only to remember that, barring Shams Tahir Khan of *Aaj Tak*, no other journalist present during Afzal's infamous press conference stage-managed by Rajbir Singh—the sometime decorated special cell police officer, encounter expert and part-time extortionist—had the gumption to report that Afzal had in fact stated that S.A.R. Geelani was in no way involved with the events of 13 December. All other journalists and the news channels that they represented, who had been present at that 'encounter' with the truth according to the Delhi Police's Special Cell, had fallen in line with Rajbir Singh's 'request' to edit out that part of Afzal's testimony. The only English language national level newspapers or publications that more or less consistently maintained an independent tone were the *Hindu* and, to some extent, *Frontline.* The only news website that toed a slightly different line was rediff.com, and the only detailed unbiased reports that were published could actually only be found in regional newspapers and publications, mainly in Kashmir, and one, oddly, in Kerala.

What this suggests is that the intensity in the court's and the national mainstream media's desire to execute Afzal and to focus on him alone actually constitutes a move to consign aspects of the truth of what lay behind